

VIRAL ILLNESS (COLD/FLU)

TIPS TO HELP CHILDREN FEEL BETTER

FOR CHILDREN OVER 1 YEAR OLD



Viral illnesses (like colds and flu) are common in children and usually get better on their own. These tips can help relieve symptoms while your child's body heals.



TEA WITH HONEY IS BEST FOR COUGH

- Honey soothes the throat and helps calm cough.
- Works better than over-the-counter cough medicines.
- Do not give honey to children under 1 year old.



DRINK PLENTY OF FLUIDS

- Fluids help thin mucus and prevent dehydration.
- Water, warm soup, and clear fluids are best choices.
- Avoid sugary drinks and limit caffeine.



REST

- Rest helps your child's body fight the virus.
- It's normal to feel tired—listen to their body.



USE A HUMIDIFIER

- Cool-mist humidifiers add moisture to the air.
- This can help ease cough, congestion, and dry or sore throats.
- Clean your humidifier daily.



SALINE NASAL SPRAY OR DROPS

- Helps loosen mucus and relieve nasal congestion.
- Safe for all ages and can be used as often as needed.
- Use a bulb syringe to gently suction younger children's noses if needed.



OVER-THE-COUNTER COUGH MEDICINE ONLY IF 6 YEARS AND OLDER

- Cough medicines may help some, but they are not better than honey.
- Always follow the dose on the package.
- Do not use cough or cold medicines in children under 6.



OTHER HELPFUL TIPS

- Use a saline nasal spray and blow or suction the nose regularly.
- Use a cool-mist humidifier, especially at night.
- For sore throat: warm salt water gargles (age 6+) or lozenges (age 6+).
- Eat a balanced diet to support your child's immune system.
- Wash hands often and cover coughs and sneezes.



WHY NO ANTIBIOTICS?

Antibiotics treat bacterial infections. Colds and flu are caused by viruses, so antibiotics will NOT help. Using antibiotics when you don't need them can cause side effects and lead to antibiotic resistance, making them less effective when you really need them.



WHEN TO SEEK CARE

Get medical help right away if your child has:

- Trouble breathing or fast breathing
- Blue lips or face
- Fever (100.4°F / 38°C or higher) that lasts more than 3 days
- Fever that goes away but comes back after improving
- Severe headache, stiff neck, or confusion
- Ear pain
- Signs of dehydration (dry mouth, no tears, not peeing)
- Symptoms that last more than 10–14 days or get worse after getting better



Most viral illnesses get better on their own in 7–10 days. Be patient and give your child's body time to heal!

WHAT TO EXPECT



Symptoms usually last 7–10 days.



Low-grade fever, cough, runny nose, and sore throat are common.



Cough may last 2–3 weeks.



Kids may feel tired or have a lower appetite.



Your child's comfort is the goal—small steps add up!



We are here to help. If you are worried at any time, please call or come back in. We hope your child feels better soon!

IF YOUR SYMPTOMS PERSIST OR WORSEN, PLEASE FOLLOW UP WITH YOUR PROVIDER.

This handout is for educational purposes only and is not a substitute for professional medical advice. Always consult your healthcare provider with any questions or concerns.